

GLMZ Stories: Vol. 1

Three rooms. Three lives. One city that doesn't notice.

Ambrosia Kiptoo-Čavić

The Cartography of Uncharted Interfaces

The last calibration log sealed at 02:47, and Ambrosia did not move for eleven seconds. She counted them. The neuro-integration ward at this hour was a particular kind of quiet — not silence, but the sound of machines doing the work that bodies couldn't, the soft rhythmic pressure of ventilators, the faint 19Hz hum that lived in the sub-levels like something that had forgotten how to leave. [sighs] Her instruments went back into their case in order. Smallest to largest. The way her mother had taught her to pack a wound kit, back when her mother still taught her things.

[thoughtful] The sailor that is careful before the storm — survives the storm.

She almost didn't open the chart. She told herself this every time, and every time her thumb found the patient ID anyway — 7-7-Kessler-ghost, the label she'd given it in her private index, the one that didn't exist in Aurochs' official taxonomy. The file bloomed across her lens overlay in pale blue. There it was. The secondary interface, dormant and architecturally impossible, mapped inside a neural mesh that Helix Biosystems had certified as single-node standard. She had read the certification herself. She had read it seven times. The ghost geography sat in the data like a room that shouldn't exist behind a wall that had no door.

[muttering] Someone built this. [annoyed] Someone built this and signed off on it and went home and slept.

She closed the overlay. Opened it again. The secondary node pulsed once in the visualization — not a real pulse, she knew that, just the rendering algorithm interpreting dormant signal as periodic — but her stomach moved anyway. Ambrosia had spent eleven years learning the difference between artifact and anomaly. This was not artifact. She had not reported it in three months because she had not yet decided what it was, and she did not report things she had not decided. This was the story she told herself. It was not entirely a lie.

The door at the ward threshold opened with the soft hydraulic exhale that meant a badge above Tier 3 clearance. She did not look up immediately. She closed the patient file with a gesture that she hoped looked like finishing something rather than hiding something, and she turned with the particular expression she had developed for administrators — attentive, slightly tired, professionally neutral. The man in the doorway wore a Helix Biosystems lanyard and a jacket that cost more than her monthly contract stipend. He had the kind of face that had been optimized rather than lived in.

The Cartography of Uncharted Interfaces

[slightly formal] "Dr. Kiptoo-ÄEaviÄ#." He said her name carefully, which meant he had practiced it, which meant this was not casual. [chuckles] "Helix has flagged some integration anomalies for routine review. Your ward shows three patients in the relevant cohort." His teeth were flawless but he smiled at her the way a locked storefront smiles at the street â€” all lit-up with no one on the inside. "I was hoping to coordinate access to the calibration records tonight, if that's convenient."

[annoyed] Convenient.

She picked up her instrument case. Clicked the latch. Set it down again.

"Tonight's records are still in processing hold," she said. "Standard forty-eight hour integration window before external access. Policy." She touched her Aurochs badge without meaning to. "I can have the coordinator send you the formal request pathway in the morning."

He looked at her for a moment that lasted slightly too long.



Orsolya's soldering iron was older than the Aurochs complex and ran hotter than it should. The coupling joint took twelve minutes. Ambrosia sat on a low stool and did not speak, and Orsolya did not require her to. The shop smelled of scorched flux and old thread and the particular sweetness of synthetic dye fading in fabric that had been washed too many times. When Orsolya set the repaired instrument case on the table, she did not ask what it was for. She charged forty Quanta, which was either very fair or very charitable, and Ambrosia could not tell which, and was too tired to ask.

She saw you. She saw the coat, the case, the way you were standing. She just didn't say it out loud. That's not kindness. That's tact. Learn the difference.

The overnight Ferrogate connector at 04:30 was three other passengers and a cargo pallet secured with Ironclad webbing, the line cutting through the decommissioned relay corridor between the Circuit's eastern edge and the Enclave's transit hub. and the sound of the maglev doing what it did â€” which was move through the world at a speed that made the world feel theoretical. The ozone came up through the floor seams. Ninety minutes of it, the

The Cartography of Uncharted Interfaces

smell of ionized air and the pressure behind her ears that never quite resolved into pain, just presence. She used the time to read the patient file again and to study the map of the Ferrogate corridor sovereign strip — a 200-meter-wide spine of corporate territory threading the length of the megalopolis, and just outside it, in the dead space where jurisdiction went to argue with itself, a decommissioned relay station that Ferrogate Transit had officially decommissioned in 2188 and that someone had apparently forgotten to stop using.

'Outside the sovereign strip' means outside the coverage. You know that. You packed the instruments anyway.

The young man was sitting on an overturned junction box when she arrived, eating something from a sealed packet that smelled of soy and synthetic umami, and he looked at her the way people in the Gray Zone looked at medical equipment — with the specific wariness of someone who had learned that care had terms and conditions. He was twenty, maybe twenty-two, with the augmentation scarring at his left temple that suggested a standard neural interface installed cheap and fast. He said his name was Milo. He said his symptoms had started six weeks ago — a pressure behind his left ear, a sense of information he couldn't access, the occasional conviction that he was remembering something he had never experienced. He said he had been to a Ferrogate contractor clinic for a wellness screening eight months ago and they had given him a clean bill of health and a transit worker loyalty card good for fifteen percent off approved purchases. He said this last part without irony. The pressure wave from a passing maglev hit the relay station walls at 04:58 and the whole structure shuddered — the junction boxes rattled, a strip of insulation peeled further from the ceiling, and Milo flinched with the trained-in reflex of someone who had been flinching at that sound for months.

Ambrosia's instruments confirmed it in three minutes and fourteen seconds. The secondary interface was there, dormant, architecturally identical to the ghost she had been not-reporting for three months — the same design signature, the same impossible elegance, the same quality of something that had been built by someone who knew exactly what they were doing and had taken great care that nobody else would. She looked at the calibration map on her lens overlay and then she looked at Milo, who was finishing his packet of synthetic soy and watching her expression with the particular attention of someone who has learned to read medical professionals for the news before the news arrives. She began

The Cartography of Uncharted Interfaces

writing. Her hand was steady. She had spent eleven years making her hands steady, and they did not betray her now. The data filled the private file she had labeled discrepancy, cross-referenced and timestamped, and underneath the technical notation she wrote four words that were not clinical language at all: *he does not know*. Outside, another maglev passed “ 280 kilometers per hour, pressure wave first, and the walls shook again, and Ambrosia kept writing.



He came through the service entrance at 05:12, and Ambrosia knew he was not Ferrogate before she finished turning around. The way he moved through the relay station was the way someone moved through a space they had memorized “ not looking for the junction boxes, not reading the layout, just navigating it the way a body navigates a room it has slept in. He was tall, angular, carrying a transit worker's bag that sat wrong on his shoulder, too light for tools and too deliberate for nothing. He stopped when he saw her. The stop was controlled “ not a flinch, not a freeze, just a recalibration so smooth she almost missed it. His hands, she noticed, were the hands of someone who maintained things. The knuckles were clean but the calluses were in the right places. Orsolya had described them without knowing she was describing them: *someone who asks about load-bearing elements*.

The still water runs deepest. But still water can drown you just the same.

"I wasn't told the clinic was sending someone." He set the bag down on a junction box “ not the one Milo had been sitting on, a different one, the one nearest the data conduit access panel. His voice was even. Not flat, not cold. Even, the way a well-maintained structure was even: load distributed, no single point under more pressure than it could bear. He looked at her instruments, at the calibration unit on the floor beside her, at the private file she had not yet closed on her lens overlay, and she watched him understand what she was in the time it took him to complete a single breath. "Neural calibrator." A pause. "Here's the thing “ that's not a Ferrogate contractor kit."

He already knows what you've written. He's deciding what to do about it.

Ambrosia did not look at Milo. She looked at the man's hands, and then at his bag, and then at the data conduit panel he had not yet opened but had positioned himself beside with the

The Cartography of Uncharted Interfaces

precision of someone who had done this twelve times before and intended to do it a thirteenth. Her documentation instinct was a physical sensation, the same one she got when a calibration map revealed something that should not be there — a pull toward the instrument, toward the notation, toward the clean certainty of recorded fact. She picked up her calibration unit. She did not put it away. "The referring physician doesn't exist," she said. Her voice came out steadier than she expected. "I checked four databases. Here's the thing — I checked them before I got on the train." She let that sit in the ozone-and-lake-water air between them. "What's the load-bearing element here?"

His expression did not change. But something behind it did — a very small adjustment, the kind that happened when a structural calculation was revised mid-load. He looked at her for a moment that lasted exactly as long as it needed to, and no longer. Outside, the Ferrogate maglev announced itself first as pressure, then as sound, then as the shudder that moved through the relay station's decommissioned bones — junction boxes rattling, insulation peeling, Milo going still in the corner with his empty packet — and in the three seconds of that particular violence, Rorke Vassiliev looked at the private file she had not yet closed and understood, with the precision of someone who had spent years identifying exactly what could not be undone, that she had already written everything down.



The Rail Hounds announced themselves before they arrived. Not sound — pressure. A different kind than the maglev, lower and more deliberate, the electromagnetic signature of autonomous enforcement platforms running a grid-scan sweep. Ambrosia felt it in her augments first, the faint copper taste that meant something external was pinging her neural interface's passive signature, and she had one second of understanding what that meant before Rorke was already moving. He had the jammer out of the transit bag — not the bag she'd been watching, a secondary pocket, and she noted this even now, even as the first platform's proximity alarm began its flat mechanical shriek from somewhere outside the station wall — and his hands moved across it with the economy of someone who had rehearsed this in the dark. "Down," he said, not loudly, and Milo dropped from the junction box to the floor with the trained compliance of someone who had learned that people who said *down* in that voice were correct, and Ambrosia did not go down, she went *sideways*,

The Cartography of Uncharted Interfaces

toward Milo, instrument case in hand, because the math of the situation was already clear to her and the math said he was the least mobile element.

The jammer triggered. The lights died with a sound that wasn't quite a sound — a frequency below hearing that she felt in her back teeth and in the scar tissue at the base of her skull where her own interface sat — and in the dark that followed came the screaming of disrupted systems, the Rail Hound platforms fragmenting from their coordination network in a cascade of error-state noise that was almost organic, almost like an animal sound. Then the wall came in. Not the whole wall. A section of it, the corrugated composite panel nearest the service entrance, and the platform that hit it was moving at assessment speed which was still considerable, and the impact was not a bang but a *compression*, the kind of sound that arrived in the body before the ears processed it, and the ceiling dropped in a diagonal and something hit Ambrosia's shoulder and she was on her knees beside Milo in the dark and his breathing was wrong.

That's a rib. Maybe two. You know what a rib sounds like. You've known since you were twenty-two and someone taught you in a place worse than this.

She worked by instrument-light and by her hands, which knew the geography of a body in crisis the way Rorke knew the geography of this station — from memory, from repetition, from the specific faith that certain truths remain stable under pressure. Her left hand found the injury site. Her right hand found the Coagulant Bloom injector in the instrument case by shape alone. She heard the second platform outside — closer, its chassis testing the doorframe once, the entire structure shuddering with the impact, Milo making a sound that she pressed her palm against his sternum to absorb, to give him something to breathe against. Across the ruined station, in the dark, she could hear Rorke holding the jammer steady against the platform's sensor array — not moving, not speaking, the absolute controlled stillness of someone running a load calculation in real time. The doorframe hit again. Dust and insulation came down. And then, in the nine seconds between the second impact and the third that did not come, Milo's secondary interface activated. She felt it before she saw it — a warmth under her palm that was not body heat, a faint bioluminescent pulse at his left temple, and then data fragments bloomed across her lens overlay unbidden, architecture she recognized the way she recognized a signature on a document she had already seen three times, and what it displayed was not patient data, not transit records, but a dead-drop communication schema so clean and so complete that she

The Cartography of Uncharted Interfaces

understood, in the space of a single breath, exactly what it was for. She kept her hands steady. She kept her face still. Outside, the second Rail Hound's coordination signal recovered on the fourth minute, and it withdrew, and the silence it left behind was the kind that would take a very long time to fill.



The transit back to the Enclave was thirty-seven minutes of Milo breathing carefully and Rorke not speaking and Ambrosia watching the dark outside the window and thinking about load-bearing elements. She had wrapped his ribs with what she had â€” the compression sleeve from the instrument case, two strips of the thermal liner she kept for post-calibration patients who went cold â€” and Milo had not complained, which meant either he was stoic or the pain was past the register where complaint was useful. She suspected both. His left temple pulsed once, faintly, in the tunnel dark, and she looked away before Rorke could see her looking.

What the hand conceals, the eye reveals. Watch your eyes, child.

Orsolya had the door open before they reached it. She took in the three of them â€” Ambrosia's shoulder, Milo's careful posture, the particular way Rorke carried his bag now, like something inside it had been used and not yet accounted for â€” and she said nothing. She moved the half-mended coat from the worktable to the back of a chair and spread a length of clean synthetic muslin across the surface without being asked, and by the time Ambrosia had Milo sitting on the table's edge, Orsolya was already at the back room's small heating unit, filling a kettle that had been filled many times before for people who had not been asked to explain themselves. The shop smelled the same as it had four hours ago. Scorched flux. Old thread. The sweetness of faded dye. Ambrosia found this steadying in a way she did not examine.

Three people in a small room. Each carrying what the others cannot see. This is not trust. This is proximity. Do not confuse them.

"The network runs dead-drop communications through transit infrastructure," Rorke said. He was standing near the door, not blocking it, but near it, and his voice was the same as it had been in the relay station â€” even, load-distributed, nothing under more pressure than

The Cartography of Uncharted Interfaces

it could bear. He was looking at Ambrosia's hands, which were working, which was where he had learned to look when he needed to know whether someone was listening. "Ferrogate sovereign strip has gaps â€” decommissioned nodes, maintenance corridors, relay stations that fell off the compliance schedule. Someone mapped them. The couriers carry fragments. No single courier carries enough to reconstruct the full schema." He paused. "Milo is one of seven." Ambrosia pressed two fingers below Milo's left rib and he exhaled sharply and she noted the location and moved on. She did not ask which seven. She did not ask what the schema was for. She was aware of the shape of what he was not saying the way she was aware of the shape of a missing node in a calibration map â€” by the space it occupied, by the way everything around it organized itself to accommodate the absence. From the back room came the sound of Orsolya's scissors moving through fabric, slow and deliberate, the sound of someone working who had decided that working was the appropriate response to the present situation. The kettle began to build toward sound. Milo looked at the ceiling and breathed.



Ambrosia set down the calibration unit. She did not reach for it again. "Here's the thing," she said, and stopped, and started again: "The schema I saw â€” the dead-drop architecture â€” that's not information brokerage. Information brokerage doesn't need seven couriers carrying fragments of itself. Information brokerage doesn't need to be that careful about being reassembled." She looked at Rorke's hands, which were still. She had learned to read stillness the way Orsolya read garments. "The gaps you mapped in the Ferrogate strip. The decommissioned nodes. Has anyone been hurt by the infrastructure work?"

The kettle reached sound and Orsolya removed it from the heat without comment. The scissors had stopped. The shop held the particular quality of a room in which three people were breathing at different rates and all of them knew it. Rorke looked at the floor â€” not away, not evasive, the way an engineer looked at a load-bearing surface they were calculating â€” and was quiet for a long time. Long enough that Milo shifted on the table edge and then went still again, understanding without being told that this was not a silence to fill.

"Meridian Core residential tower," Rorke said. "Cooling system. 2191, February, the

The Cartography of Uncharted Interfaces

fourteenth." His voice was the same. Even. Load-distributed. The evenness was doing more work now than it had done all night. "The failure cascade was a consequence of a maintenance access reroute I introduced to the building's infrastructure management layer. I had modeled the reroute for six failure scenarios. The seventh was â€” the interaction between the reroute and a pre-existing fault in the secondary coolant loop that was not in any documentation I had access to. Two maintenance workers were in the substation when the pressure release triggered." He paused. "I have run the simulation four hundred and twelve times. The fault was not in the documentation. The fault was not foreseeable from the data I had." He said this the way someone said a thing they had said to themselves many times, in the dark, in the specific register of a man who had decided that precision was the closest he could come to honesty. "The simulation confirms this each time."

The simulation is not for the workers. The simulation is for him. You know what that is. You have your own version of it.

Ambrosia looked at him for a moment. She did not soften her face. She had spent eleven years learning not to soften her face when the data required her to hold it steady, and she held it steady now, and what she felt underneath the steadiness she did not examine, because examining it would cost her the next sentence and the next sentence was the one that mattered. "What is the simulation for," she said, "if you already know the answer you need from it?" She said it quietly, not as accusation, not as absolution, as a calibration question â€” the kind she asked when a map revealed a node that shouldn't exist and she needed to understand what the node was doing there before she could decide what to write down. From the doorway to the back room, Orsolya stood with the kettle in both hands and her white hair close-pinned and her face arranged in the expression of someone who had heard many things in this shop and had learned that most of them were not about what they appeared to be about. She looked at Rorke. She looked at the floor where his gaze had been. She said, without inflection, without hurry: "A seam that keeps tearing is not a seam problem. It's a pattern problem." Then she set the kettle on the worktable and went back to her scissors, and the sound of them resumed, slow and deliberate, and the shop held its smell of scorched flux and old thread and the sweetness of something that had been washed too many times to remember its original color.

The Cartography of Uncharted Interfaces



Orsolya's scissors did not stop while Ambrosia wrote. That was the sound of it — the slow deliberate shear of fabric, and underneath it the scratch of Ambrosia's stylus against the documentation overlay, and underneath that the careful sound of Milo breathing. She wrote the suppressed chart first. Patient 7-7-Kessler-ghost, three months of not-reporting rendered into precise clinical language that did not soften what it described. Then the secondary interface: its architecture, its dormancy signature, its design quality — *exceptional, intentional, concealed by someone with access to Helix certification infrastructure* — and she did not flinch from that sentence, she wrote it twice, the second time more precisely than the first. The Rail Hound incident. The jammer. The data fragments that had bloomed across her overlay when Milo's interface activated in the dark, and what they meant when read as a schema rather than noise. She wrote Rorke's name. She wrote the two maintenance workers — she did not know their names, so she wrote *two maintenance workers, Meridian Core residential tower, February 14, 2191, cooling system failure, deaths attributed to infrastructure cascade* — and she cross-referenced it to the dead-drop architecture with a notation that said *connection unverified, pattern consistent*. Her hand did not shake. She had spent eleven years making her hand not shake, and it did not betray her now, and she was aware that this was the most complete documentation of her career and that she was going to do something with it that was not filing it with Aurochs.

You know what this is. You have known since you got on the train at 04:30. The question was never whether to write it down. The question was always who deserved to receive it.

She stripped the patient identifiers last. Milo's name, his transit worker ID, the Ferrogate clinic's wellness screening record — all of it excised with the same precision she used to excise artifact from a calibration map, leaving the architecture clean and readable and belonging to no one in particular. What remained was the interface design itself: its signal topology, its dormancy parameters, its activation threshold, the specific elegance of how it had been made to look like nothing. She looked at it for a moment. Then she looked at Rorke, who was watching her hands, and she said: "The dead-drop system. Can it receive as well as distribute?" He looked at her. The evenness in his face did something very small — not a crack, not a fracture, more like the slight adjustment of a load-bearing wall accepting

The Cartography of Uncharted Interfaces

weight it had been designed to accept. "Yes," he said. "The contact chain from the courier network," she said. "Here's the thing — I need the first node only. Not the full schema." She held up the stripped file. "Someone built this interface. Someone in that network needs to know what it looks like from the inside."

Orsolya came out of the back room with the coat folded over her arm and set it on the table beside Milo without ceremony. It was the same coat — the same worn synthetic canvas, the same fraying at the left cuff — but the collar had been restructured, the lining thickened at the left shoulder and neck in a way that was invisible until you knew to look for it, the augmentation scar at his left temple now sitting behind two layers of material that would scatter a passive scanner's read. She smoothed the collar with two fingers. "The seam will hold," she said. She did not say *you're welcome* because she had not been thanked, and she did not appear to require it. Milo put the coat on slowly, carefully, the way a person put on something that had just been made to protect them, and for a moment his face was the face of someone very young who had not expected care to arrive in this particular form.

Rorke left before the sky changed. He took the jammer and the transit bag and the first node of the contact chain, and he did not say goodbye, which was correct — goodbyes created records, and records were load-bearing elements in the wrong kind of structure. Ambrosia sent the formal notification to the Helix liaison at 06:44: *the original anomalous chart for the flagged integration cohort contained a documentation error in the calibration timestamp sequence; the corrected file is attached; no further anomalies identified*. She clipped her badge to her lapel. The badge she had worn for eleven years, the one she touched without meaning to when the Helix man had stood in her ward threshold with his practiced smile. She clipped it on and felt the difference — not identity, she understood now, armor — and picked up her instrument case and walked out into the Enclave's early light, which was the thin gray of a city that had been up all night and was not yet pretending otherwise. The maglev took ninety minutes. She watched Lake Michigan through the window for most of them — the oldest thing in the corridor, the one thing that predated every corponation, every tier, every certification database she had checked. It did not look back. It was entirely indifferent to what she had just done, and she found, in that indifference, something that was not comfort exactly, but was close enough to hold onto for the length of the journey.

The Cartography of Uncharted Interfaces



The Last Chair

Protagonist: Dhriti Nakamura

Act 1: The Contract Arrives

The clippers came out before the sun did. Echo had done it this way for thirty-one years “ pulled the case from beneath the counter, unlatched the three brass clips in order, left to right, never right to left, and laid each tool on the cloth like he was setting a table for someone important. Which he was. The cloth was red once. Now it was the color of old brick, soft as a broken-in glove, and it smelled like the mineral oil he pressed into it every Sunday without exception.

Some things you do because they work. Some things you do because stopping would mean admitting something.

He did not rush the polishing. The shop was dim at this hour “ the neon outside still sleeping, the street beyond the window showing only the grey suggestion of Calle Ochenta waking up wrong, the way it always did: a cart before a person, a smell before a sound. Carnitas smoke from the tamale counter next door threading through the ventilation gap he'd never gotten around to sealing. He noticed it the way you notice your own heartbeat. Steady. Present. Proof.

The log came next. Paper. Always paper. He pressed his thumb to the ink pad “ habit, not necessity “ and pressed it into the corner of the page the way his father had shown him on a different continent in a different century when paper meant something it no longer meant to anyone else in this city. *Tuesday*, he wrote. *Calle Ochenta. 47th year of operation. Weather: Glooms rain, redirected, present since 0300.* He paused. The pen hovered. He wrote one more line he always wrote and had never shown anyone: *The shop is still here.*

The Chair held the room the way an elder holds a room “ not by demanding attention but by making the space around it smaller. It was not a beautiful chair. It was not meant to be. The hydraulics had been replaced twice, the leather patched in four places with material that didn't quite match, and the chrome footrest had a long scar along the left side from a night in 2241 that Echo did not discuss. But when the morning light finally came through the east window “ weak, watered-down Gray Zone light, the kind the atmospheric processors left over after they'd skimmed the good wavelengths for the Spires “ it landed

The Last Chair

on the Chair first. It always did. Echo believed this was not an accident. He had stopped explaining why to people who asked.

He unlocked the front door at 0612. Thirty-one years of 0612, give or take the nights that bled into mornings he'd rather not account for. The lock turned clean. The sign flipped. He stood in the doorway one moment — long enough to read the street, which was a skill, which was a necessity, which was something the young ones were losing because they read their overlays instead of the actual human beings moving through actual space — and that was when he saw the boy sitting on the curb across the street, knees pulled to his chest, wearing a jacket two sizes too large and no augments that Echo could see. No overlay glow. No neural indicator light at the temple. Nothing. The boy was looking directly at the shop. Had been, Echo suspected, for some time.

Now —



The boy was still looking when the courier turned the corner.

Echo saw the courier first — the badge on the lanyard catching the weak morning light, Tessera compliance division, silver and blue, the colors of something that had decided it was permanent. The courier was young, maybe twenty-five, with the careful posture of someone who had been told what this job was before they understood what this job was. She walked like she had practiced the walk. She did not look at the boy on the curb. Most people didn't look at boys on curbs anymore. Echo looked. He looked at both of them at the same time, which was a skill, and then he stepped back into the doorway and let the courier come to him.

She said the name of the business, not his name. That was the first thing. She held out the envelope with both hands, which was the second thing. He took it the same way — both hands, unhurried, the way you accept something from someone who does not know what they are carrying. The envelope was heavy paper, cream-colored, and had the word *CONDITIONAL* printed across the top in a font designed to feel like information rather than threat, which meant it was a threat. He did not open it in front of her. He said, "Thank you." She said something about sixty days and acknowledgment of receipt and he pressed his

The Last Chair

thumb to the scanner she produced without looking at the scanner, the way he pressed his thumb to the log, and she left. He watched her go. Then he looked back at the curb. The boy had not moved.

Now â€”

He opened the envelope inside, standing behind the counter, back to the window. He read the document once. The language said *heritage corridor consolidation*. It said *zoning reclassification, Category 7, effective immediately*. It said *sixty days from date of notice to achieve compliance or initiate voluntary vacate proceedings*. The word *voluntary* was doing a great deal of work in that sentence. He folded the document along its original crease â€” not in half, not in thirds, but along the fold it had come with, which felt like the correct decision for reasons he could not have explained â€” and put it under the counter, beneath the cloth, next to the case. Then he turned around. The first customer of the day was already at the door, an old man named Fortunato who had been coming every other Tuesday since 2238 and who never asked questions because he had learned that Echo would eventually answer the ones that mattered. Echo held the door. He gestured to the Chair. He picked up the scissors. Outside on the curb, the boy had finally stood up. He was still watching.



Act 2: What the Archive Knows

Fortunato's hair was finished before ten. Echo swept the floor after, not because it needed sweeping yet but because the broom was something to hold, and then he put on his coat, and then he stood in front of the counter for a moment looking at the cloth without lifting it. The tail moved against his hip in slow, unhurried loops. He pressed it flat with one hand. Then he picked up the envelope from beneath the cloth, put it in his inside breast pocket, turned the sign to *CLOSED â€” BACK BY NOON*, and walked out into the Grooms rain without locking the door all the way.

He has done this before. Not with this. But the motion is the same: the thing you carry to someone else because you cannot look at it alone anymore, dressed up as something practical, something professional, something that has nothing to do with the fact that your

The Last Chair

hands stopped being quite steady the moment you read the word voluntary.

The Annex was twelve minutes on foot through the kind of morning that smelled like wet concrete and someone else's breakfast. He did not take the transit. He needed the twelve minutes. Remi was at her usual table when he arrived — a folding thing barely visible beneath three towers of physical media, and she was wearing the reading glasses she claimed not to need, and she did not look up when he came in because she had heard his particular footstep in this building for long enough that she did not need to. He set the envelope on the one clear corner of her table. He said, "I am not here for help. I need a second set of eyes on some language."

She picked it up. She read it the way she read everything — completely still except for the brass fingers tapping once, twice against her knee, then stopping. Under two minutes. She set it down. She stood, moved to the small heating unit in the corner without a word, and filled two cups. When she came back she set one in front of him and held the other in her real hand and looked at the document rather than at him.

"As the record shows," she said, and paused, and chose the exact word: "this is not a contract." She tapped the phrase with one brass finger, gently, as if she were pointing out a name in a photograph. "*Heritage corridor consolidation*. I have seen this language twice. The first time, it was the Velez building on Archer's Line. The second time, the Mireille cooperative on Calle Sur." She lifted her tea. She did not say what happened to those buildings. She did not need to. "They file this document because it must exist before the demolition order can be issued. It is designed to look like negotiation." She looked at him then, over the rim of the cup. "It is not negotiation, Echo."



The Kessler Interchange smelled like ozone and old carbon and the particular human exhaustion of people who had been standing in the same place for too long. Echo and Remi came in from the lower entrance, the one near the secondary platform where the Pulse corridor ran beneath the floor and sent its thrumline up through the soles of your shoes whether you wanted it or not — that low 8 Hz shiver that the long-timers stopped noticing and the newcomers never stopped mentioning. Echo noticed it. He always noticed it. The

The Last Chair

tail pressed flat against his hip of its own accord.

The first time he came to this platform, it was for a different reason. The shrine was smaller then. Stile had been newer, or whatever new meant for a thing that had never been born.

The shrine occupied the alcove between the eastbound departure gate and the maintenance corridor — a recessed space that Ferrogate Transit officially classified as a structural utility node and unofficially left alone because the E.L.F. that had taken root there three years before the Interchange opened had, in some unmeasured way, made the platform run better. The offerings were small and eclectic: a polished transit token, a handwritten timetable folded into a bird, a cup of something hot that someone had left that morning and not yet gone cold. The amber light that pulsed from the alcove was faint and irregular, the way a heartbeat is irregular when it is sleeping.

Mehdi was working the gate at the far end, her back half-turned, hands moving through the practiced geometry of her shift — scan, pass, redirect, scan. The copper threading in her hair caught the platform lights in slow sequences. She saw them coming before they reached the midpoint of the platform. Echo knew she did because her head did not move but the tactical eye shifted, a flat gray degree of attention, and her hands did not stop moving. She finished three more passengers before she let the line thin and stepped back from the gate to the edge of the platform, hands clasped at her back, facing the tracks.

"Move along," she said, to no one in particular. Then, quieter, not quite turning: "You are not vendors. You are not transit. You are standing on my platform with an envelope in your pocket, sir, and you have been walking like a man carrying something heavy since you came through the lower entrance." A pause. The thrumline moved through the floor. Somewhere beneath them, a slug was coasting through its corridor at Mach 6, sealed and silent and moving through a vacuum that had no patience for hesitation. "The number on the badge." She said it without preamble, without looking at them. "The courier who brought it. Silver-blue lanyard, Tessera compliance, four-digit suffix." She finally turned. The warm brown eye held them. The gray one was already somewhere else, scanning the platform. "You want to know what that number is."

It was not a question.

The Last Chair



Mehdi held the silence the way the platform held the thrumline — present, structural, not asking permission. Then she said, "3847. That is the suffix." She said it the way you say a street address you have memorized without meaning to. "That unit is not general compliance." She turned back to the gate. Another passenger. Scan, pass. "3847 is pre-relocation. They arrive sixty days before the order. They file the document. They photograph the faces of people who read it." She paused for one full second. "I have been watching 3847 come through this platform for eight months."

Echo did not move. The tail was flat against his hip, pressed there by his own hand, and he left it there. Eight months. The envelope in his breast pocket was sixty days. The math was not difficult. He looked at Remi without turning his head — a small shift, peripheral, the way you check something you already know is there — and she was already looking at him, the brass fingers closed into a quiet fist at her side.

"I have been carrying a thing," Mehdi said, still facing the gate. Her voice was lower now, not quieter, but pulled closer to the floor, the way you speak in a space where the walls remember. "Three years. A sealed package. Someone said to me, *when you know what to do with it, you will know*. I did not know what to do with it." She let one more passenger through. "I think I know now."

The Annex was cold when they got back. Remi did not turn on the overhead light. She moved to the far wall, to the lower shelf that ran beneath the water-stained cabinet, and pulled out a case that looked like nothing — grey polymer, scuffed corners, the kind of thing you look past because it resembles everything else that is meant to be looked past. She set it on the table. She did not open it immediately. She pressed both palms flat against the surface, real hand and brass hand, and looked at Echo across the case the way you look at someone before a door opens that cannot be closed again. Then she opened it. The drive inside was sealed in archival polymer. She broke the seal. She inserted it into the port at the base of her skull without ceremony. The amber rings in her eyes went still for three seconds. Then she sat down — not carefully, not with her usual controlled economy, but the way a person sits when the floor has shifted without warning. "Echo," she said. She said his name the way she had never said it before. She turned the display toward him. The file was flagged

The Last Chair

in red. *Employee: Nakamura-Petelo, Yusuf.* Junior grade. Compliance analyst. Washburn Commons consolidation project. The log in his coat pocket “the one where one name had been circled for three years in the same ink as *the shop is still here*” stayed in his pocket. His hands did not move toward it.



The rain had stopped by the time Echo walked back to the shop alone, but the street was still wet, still dark, still doing its redistributed-storm impression of something honest. He did not hurry. He turned the sign back to *OPEN* at six minutes past noon, exactly, and he put on water for tea he did not drink, and he stood behind the counter and looked at the Chair and waited for whatever was going to happen next to happen.

They came at eleven-seventeen. He knew what they were before they reached the door “the way you know weather before the pressure drops, the way you know a blade is wrong before you test it. Two of them. Not large, exactly, but constructed for purpose, wearing the flat dark jackets that Tessera's private enforcement arm had decided made them look like authority rather than what they were. One carried a case. The plasma cutter smell preceded him by half a meter, that particular metallic sweetness that meant something was about to stop existing. The other had a tablet and the expression of a man who had been told this would be routine.

Now “

Echo was in the doorway before they reached it. Not outside “in it, exactly in it, the threshold itself, the scissors in his right hand held low and open, not raised, not threatening, just present the way a tool is present in the hand of someone who knows how to use it. He said, “This is my floor.” He said it the same way he had said every important thing in thirty-one years: without raising his voice, without looking away, without giving the words anywhere to go except directly into the chest of the man in front of him. “And you are going to leave it.”

They did not leave it.

What happened next was not a fight the way fights are described. There was no

The Last Chair

choreography to it. The contractor with the tablet stepped forward and Echo stepped with him and the scissors were still low but the contractor's wrist met the counter's edge in a way that was not an accident, and the case hit the floor, and the Chair — the patched and scarred and irreplaceable Chair — caught the other man's elbow as he swung wide and the sound of the old leather giving way was worse than any of the other sounds. The shrine on the wall shelf took a glancing blow from the case lid swinging open and the transit token offering fell and rang against the tile twice and was still. Echo was bleeding from the knuckle of his left hand from something he had not felt happen. He had the contractor by the jacket front and he was saying something — he was not certain what, later — when Mehdi came through the door.

She did not run. She walked in the way that the door had been left open for her, which it had been, and she positioned herself between Echo and the two contractors with the particular economy of someone who has calculated the geometry of a platform a thousand times, and she reached up and tapped the side of her tactical eye with two fingers, audibly, in the way you tap a microphone to let a room know it is live. "Recording," she said. Her voice had dropped that half-register, the one that meant the calm was real and also not entirely safe. "Both faces. Both badges. Timestamp." The contractor with the tablet looked at his partner. The contractor with the case looked at the door. Mehdi did not move. "You understand me," she said. It was not a question and it was not an invitation and after four seconds that felt like a duration with weight and texture, they left. The door swung. The street took them.

Echo stood in the center of his floor and looked at the broken chair and the fallen token and the scorch mark on the doorframe from a plasma cutter that had been tested, briefly, against the wood, and he realized his hands were shaking. Not trembling. Shaking — a fine, persistent vibration that he had no mechanism for stopping because he had never needed one before. He pressed them flat against the counter, the way Remi had pressed hers against the case, and he looked at Mehdi, who was pressing two fingers against her right side and not quite hiding that it hurt. He said her name. She did not answer immediately. Then she said, "I have footage I don't know what to do with." She exhaled through her nose. She looked at the fallen token on the floor, the offering from someone's morning that was now part of a different story. "Maybe now I do."

The Last Chair



Act 3: What You Keep

Remi found the broom behind the door where it had always been and began to sweep without asking. The sound of it “bristles against tile, the small bright ring of the transit token being nudged aside” was the loudest thing in the room for a long time. Mehdi sat with her back against the wall beneath the shelf where the shrine had been, two fingers pressed to her right side, not hiding it anymore, just managing it. Echo stood at the counter. His hands had stopped shaking, or he had stopped noticing them shake, which was not the same thing but felt like it. The Chair was in front of him. The leather had given at the patch near the armrest “the oldest patch, the one from 2241, the one he had done himself with material that didn't match and had never bothered to correct because the mismatch was part of what was true about the thing. He looked at the tear. He did not touch it.

"I did not refuse the offer because of the neighborhood," he said.

Remi stopped sweeping. She did not look up immediately. The brass fingers curled around the broom handle and she stood still, as if the sentence were a page that needed to be held flat before it could be read. Mehdi's fingers pressed two more degrees into her side and then released.

"I have a son." He said it the way he wrote *the shop is still here* “plainly, without apology, as information the world had simply not been given yet. "Yusuf. He is thirty-four years old. He was twelve the last time he sat in that chair." He gestured toward it with nothing “not a hand, not a look, just the faint orientation of his body. "I cut his hair. He was angry with me about something I do not remember. Children are often angry and then they forget why, and I thought he would forget." The tail moved once against his hip, a single slow curl, then went still. "He did not forget. He left. He did very well for himself. He works for Tessera. He is a junior analyst on the Washburn Commons consolidation project." He reached beneath the counter and placed the log on the surface, closed. He did not open it. "I have been keeping the shop for a boy who is not twelve anymore and who is not coming back to be twelve again. I knew this. I have known it for a long time. But the shop is the last place he

The Last Chair

knew me as his father, and I could notâ€”" He stopped. He pressed one hand flat against the counter, the way Remi had pressed hers against the case. "I could not let that be a parking structure."

He did not say anything else. The broom started again, slowly, and the tile gave back its small bright sounds.



Remi set the broom against the wall and sat down at the counter without asking. She opened the port at the base of her skull with the practiced motion of someone accessing a filing cabinet they have used every day for forty years, and she did not look at Echo while she worked, and she did not explain what she was looking for because she had already found it three seconds into the search and explaining would have required her to say his son's name twice in the same room and she was not willing to do that to him. The brass fingers moved against the counter surface in small, precise patterns. The amber rings in her eyes went still. Then she made one transmission â€” not from her registered address, not from anything that could be traced to this shop or to Echo or to a woman who had been holding a sealed package for three years without knowing why. She routed it through the Washburn Commons archive node, which was a thing she had built herself in 2241 and which the city had forgotten existed because she had needed the city to forget. The message contained no name. No signature. One date: the fourteenth of March, twelve years ago, logged in handwriting that belonged to one man in this city. She closed the connection. She sat for a moment with her palms flat on the counter, real hand and brass hand, and then she said, quietly, to the surface rather than to Echo: "Then perhaps the shop is not the message you need to send him."

Mehdi moved without announcement. She had been sitting beneath the empty shelf for the duration of Remi's work, two fingers against her side, not pressing anymore, just resting there â€” monitoring, the way you monitor a system you have learned to manage without curing. She stood in the careful way of someone who has made a calculation about what the body will permit, and she pulled the small sealed drive from the inside pocket of her jacket, and she looked at it for one moment the way you look at a thing you have carried so long you have forgotten its weight. She plugged it into the portable node she carried on her belt â€”

The Last Chair

transit-issue, which meant it had four broadcast channels she was not supposed to use for personal transmissions and which she had been not using for personal transmissions for eight months while she waited to know what she was waiting for. She sent the footage and the compliance package to three Gray Zone network nodes whose addresses she had memorized from a list she had received and never written down. The fourth transmission went to the Ferrogate internal oversight channel, which would sit unread for thirty-six hours and then be flagged, and then be referred to a committee, and then be discussed in a room she would never be invited into. She knew this. She sent it anyway. She unplugged the drive and put it back in her pocket and looked at Echo, and she said nothing, and he looked back at her, and he did not say thank you because she had not done it for him and they both understood that.

He opened the shop the next morning at 0612. The log was waiting on the counter where he had left it, and he opened it to the next clean page, and he pressed his thumb to the ink pad “left to right, never right to left” and he wrote *Wednesday. Calle Ochenta*. He paused at the weather. The atmospheric processors had redirected last night's storm the way they always did, which meant the street was wet with someone else's rain, which was the only kind of rain the Gray Zone ever got, and he wrote that down too. Then he wrote the line he always wrote. *The shop is still here*. He closed the log. He turned to the Chair, which had the new tear in the oldest patch, the one he had done himself in 2241 with material that didn't match, and he did not touch the tear. He picked up the scissors. He stood behind the Chair and he waited, the way the Chair had always waited “not asking permission, not demanding anything, just present in the morning light that came through the east window and landed where it always landed, unhurried, as if it had nowhere else to be.



Every Road Leads Back

Protagonist: Felicitas Madrigal

Act 1: The Known Roads

The tamales are already cold.

He knows this before he lifts the cloth. His hands know it — the weight wrong, the heat gone since before he arrived. He lifts the cloth anyway. Three tamales from the Canto woman, \$1.4 each, corn masa gone rigid at the seam. He eats standing. Doesn't sit. Sitting is for places he means to stay.

Some mornings the food is beside the point.

The shrine is a milk crate nailed to the corrugated wall of what used to be a lakeshore processing shed, now a crÃche, now a rumor. Waukegan light comes in flat and gray through gaps in the roofing. He has left: one bottle cap, one dried seed pod, one folded square of paper with a route written in his hand — not for reading, for weight. He has done this at forty-seven shrines between here and the Kenosha Crossing. He does not pray. He marks. *Mark it.* The distinction matters to him even if no one else understands the difference.

He begins the recitation under his breath while his jaw works the cold masa.

Waukegan lateral, bearing two-seven-zero until the overpass that smells of copper — then you dog-leg north, cuidado at the second junction, there's a load-bearing gap the maps don't show, they never show the gaps, los mapas mienten, the maps always lie, pero tu cuerpo sabe, your body knows — mark the grain elevator with the painted bird, that is your true north from the Crossing to the Rail Margin, you understand where I am —

He stops.

Someone is watching him from the doorway. Not hiding. Not threatening. Just standing there in the flat Waukegan light, holding something in both hands — cloth wrapped around an object he can't read from here. Young. Seventeen, maybe. The scarification on the boy's jaw is fresh, keloid-proud, three marks on the left side only. Half a set. Someone started the marks and stopped.

Every Road Leads Back

Ash chews. Swallows. Does not reach for anything.

The boy says a name. A name that has not been spoken at Ash in eleven years, from a mouth that should not know it.



The drone comes in through the gap in the roofing before Ash has finished deciding what to do about the boy.

Small thing. Matte gray, no markings, hovering at exactly the height of his synthetic eye — not his good eye, the other one, the milky one — holding position with the particular stillness of something that has been programmed to be patient. Ash does not move. The boy in the doorway does not move. The drone extends a filament arm and deposits a data-chip on the milk crate shrine, next to his folded paper route, next to the bottle cap, next to the dried seed pod. Then it rises six centimeters and waits. He touches the frame of his synthetic eye — a habit he cannot account for, a thing his hand does when his mind needs to slow down — and looks at the chip, then at the drone, then at the boy. *Mark it.* None of these things are connected. He has no evidence they are connected. He has forty years of evidence that things arriving in threes are always connected.

"Don't pick it up yet." A woman's voice from behind him, from the direction of the alley exit he had catalogued when he entered — the one with the bent corrugated panel and the boot-width gap. He had noted two exits. She had come through the third. He had missed the third. He turns, slow, chewing nothing, his jaw still working the ghost of the last tamale. She is already in the room. She checked the other exit — the main door, the boy's doorway — before she looked at him. He watched her eyes do it. She does not acknowledge that he watched. "Brisa," she says, not as greeting but as inventory. She is giving him her name the way you give someone a tool. *Here. Use it correctly.*

The chip on the shrine catches the flat Waukegan light. Analog casing, no reader port he can see from here, no corporate stamp. He asks — carefully, the way you ask a question you already know will not be answered fully — where the package originates. She says, *secured origin*. He asks what it contains. She says, *secured contents*. He asks why it cannot move through the hyperlane network like everything else. She pauses mid-breath, that half-

Every Road Leads Back

second gap that is not hesitation but calculation, and says, *secured reason*. Three questions. Three careful doors, all locked from the other side. He exhales through his nose — the long exhale, the one that precedes his disagreements — and picks up the chip. The package, when she produces it from under her coat, is the size of a folded shirt, wrapped in gray cloth, and it smells of something he cannot immediately name. Something warm. Something domestic. Something that should not be in this room. He does not say this. He touches the frame of his synthetic eye again and looks at the 1800 written on the paper she hands him, and he looks at the boy still standing in the doorway with his half-finished marks and his cloth-wrapped object, and he thinks: *los mapas mienten*. And then he thinks: *Escanaba*.



The boy leaves first. No word, no gesture — he simply turns and the doorway is empty. The cloth-wrapped object goes with him. Ash watches the space where he stood and files it: *unresolved*. His hand drops from his synthetic eye.

They walk north. Brisa does not explain why north. She does not explain much of anything for the first forty minutes, which Ash reads as professional courtesy. He does the same. He recites the Iron Bend checkpoint mnemonic under his breath — *bearing three-four-five, the second gate, the inspector who prays water, leave something wet at the shrine* — and Brisa, walking two paces to his left and watching the sightlines he is not watching, says without looking at him: "How long did it take to learn them all."

Not a question. An inventory.

"Longer than I had," Ash says. "Less long than I needed." He pauses. The exhale. "Someone taught me the northern routes. The checkpoints between here and Escanaba. The particular kindnesses of particular inspectors on particular days of the week." He does not say who. She does not ask. The silence after is the shape of a door that neither of them opens.

They know what buildings look like before they come down. He thinks this looking at her, the way she moves — the slight forward lean, weight on the balls of her feet, hands loose, head tracking without turning. He has seen that economy before, in people who have stood inside structures as they were being unmade. People who can feel the load-bearing walls by the way the floor changes under their boots. She says, still watching the sightlines:

Every Road Leads Back

"Escanaba. There's a block." Pause. "Residential. Twelve stories, poured concrete, cast in the nineties" — the actual nineties, not the rebuilt nineties. Pre-corporation pour. You understand what that means structurally." Another pause, the calculating kind. "Three hundred and forty units. Civilian proximity. The blast radius would be —" Her voice goes flat. Not empty. Flat the way a detonator wire goes flat before the charge. "Would be a problem," she finishes. "My problem, if they'd called me for the job." She has not said who *they* are. She has not said she was called. "They didn't," she adds, which answers nothing.

Ash touches the frame of his synthetic eye. *Mark it.* The package under his coat smells like something warm, something domestic — he has the word now, the word he could not find in the shed. It smells like the inside of a lived-in building. Like someone's floor. He walks and does not say this and keeps walking and does not say this.



Act 2: The Unmapped Territory

The first checkpoint is at the junction where Archer's Line crosses under the old elevated freight spur — a narrow passage, three people wide, with a Ferrogate Transit camera housing that has not worked in four years. Ash knows this because he memorized the maintenance schedule from a man who drank too much at a rest stop in Kenosha and told him everything. He leads without announcing that he is leading. He simply walks a certain way and the other two fall into position behind him, because that is what bodies do when they recognize someone who knows the ground. Brisa takes his left flank without being asked. Two meters overhead, barely audible, a matte-gray drone moves with them — smaller than his fist, quieter than the wind off the lake. He had not seen Emeka. He has still not seen Emeka. What he has seen is the drone, and the relay light blinking amber at Brisa's neural jack, and the way she tilts her head two degrees to the right when data comes in. He has catalogued this. He recites the checkpoint mnemonic under his breath: *the second camera housing, the gap in the fence by the red chalk mark, the inspector who does not ask if you move correctly* — you understand where I am. The inspector is a woman in her fifties with a Ferrogate Transit vest and a wrist brace. She looks at his patchwork coat. She looks at the package under his coat, the gray cloth edge just visible at the lapel. She looks at

Every Road Leads Back

the shrine bolted to the junction post — a water E.L.F. shrine, a small one, ceramic cup at the base. Ash reaches into his coat and produces a small bottle of filtered lake water, pours two fingers into the cup without breaking stride. The inspector looks away. They pass. Behind him, he hears nothing from Brisa. That is her version of approval.

The second and third checkpoints are smaller courtesies — a gate operator at the Waukegan lateral who prays on Wednesdays and is therefore distracted, a transit authority kiosk running on a six-second authentication delay that Ash has timed on forty-three separate crossings. *Six seconds, no more, the camera pans right at the count of three, you step through at four — mark it.* He does not explain any of this aloud. He performs it and the others follow. He is aware, in the way he is always aware of the shape of his own competence, that this is what he is for — not the package, not the destination, not the \$800. This. The accumulated kindness of forty years of paying attention to things no one else thought worth recording. The drone overhead tilts slightly, reorienting. Ash watches it without appearing to watch it. *Mark it.* Emeka is paying attention to something.

"Cross-referencing the residential registry," says a voice through the relay — not in the room, not walking with them, the voice of someone several hundred meters above and behind them, speaking through Brisa's neural jack and out her earpiece. Flat and technical, the voice of a man more comfortable with aerial footage than eye contact. "Escanaba block. Twelve-story, poured concrete. I need to flag any registered residents who might complicate a security assessment." A pause. The sound of data processing, which is no sound at all but Ash has learned to read pauses the way he reads gaps in fence lines. "Three hundred and thirty-one current registrations. Pulling names now." Another pause. The drone overhead tilts again, a degree, two degrees, the way Emeka's drones tilt when he is giving something more attention. The voice reads a name.

Four syllables. A first name and a surname, two words, spoken without weight or context by a man who does not know what they cost. Ash goes completely still. Not the stillness of someone stopping — the stillness of someone who has been stopped from the inside, the body locking before the mind has finished the order. His hand moves to his coat. Not to the lapel. Lower, to the left side, to a pocket that has been stitched shut with red thread — not sealed, not damaged, stitched shut deliberately, the thread worn smooth at the knot from years of his thumb finding it in the dark. He does not open the pocket. His thumb rests against the stitching and his chest does not move for three full seconds and the drone above

Every Road Leads Back

them holds its position with the patience of something that has been programmed to wait.



The drone tilts three degrees east and holds.

Brisa's hand is already moving when the first contractor comes over the yard fence — not toward her weapon but to Ash's arm, fingers closing around his wrist and pulling him sideways into the shadow of a switching cart before he has finished not breathing. The yard smells of oxidized iron and standing water. No civilians. Not one window lit in any direction. *Mark it.* The lateral junction — this specific junction, the one with the collapsed signal housing and the three converging rail lines and the gap in the chain-link that forms a natural bottleneck — was chosen by someone who knew its geometry. Ash knows its geometry. He has walked it. He knows the distances.

Four contractors. ACS-stamped vests, the good ones with the stiffened front panels, moving in a formation that says *trained but not current* — the spacing is textbook but their feet are wrong, their feet are corporate-yard wrong, they have not trained in a place that floods. Ash pulls the cart. Not throws, not shoves — *pulls*, using the momentum of his own retreat, letting two hundred kilos of abandoned switching equipment pivot on its corroded wheel and narrow the eastern approach to one person wide. He does this without announcement. He does this the way he recites mnemonics, the way he pours water into ceramic cups — *mark it* — and then he is behind the cart with his back against cold iron and the package still under his coat, still warm, still smelling of someone's floor.

Brisa is elsewhere. He knows this because the sound from the east is different from the sound from the north, and the eastern sound is one contractor and then none, and the northern sound is Brisa moving between two freight housings in the dark like a structural equation being solved in real time. Emeka's voice comes through the relay, shaking in a way it was not shaking before, saying *third contact, bearing two-one-five, he's inside your perimeter, he's* — and then the fourth contractor is on Ash's side of the cart and Ash is not Brisa, Ash has never been Brisa, Ash has survived forty years of being in the wrong place by being the one who does not fight. He recites under his breath — not a mnemonic, not a route, something else, two syllables, repeated, the rhythm of someone pressing cloth to a

Every Road Leads Back

wound before they know they have one. The blow catches him in the ribs, left side, and he goes down against the cart's wheel housing and the package does not fall because his body has already curled around it, the way his body has been curling around things that needed protecting since before he understood what protecting cost. He hears Brisa arrive. He hears what she does to the fourth contractor. He does not look. He presses his forearm against his ribs and breathes shallow and recites, quiet, *los mapas mienten, tu cuerpo sabe, mark it, you understand where I am*

Through the relay, Emeka's voice: "I watched all of it." A pause that is not calculation. A pause that is something else, something Emeka has no technical vocabulary for. "I watched all of it and I couldn't " He stops. The drone overhead descends four meters and holds. "The third contact had an internal code designation on his vest panel. Stenciled, not printed. I ran it." Another pause, the data kind, but the voice underneath it is still shaking. "That code is six days old. The designation doesn't match any contract issued in the last seventy-two hours." Ash does not move from the wheel housing. He hears this. He files it. *Mark it.* Someone was running this operation before Brisa took the contract. Someone was running this operation before the chip landed on the shrine. He touches the stitched pocket with his thumb " the red thread, worn smooth, the knot that has never been untied " and above him, in the flat post-dawn light of the Lateral Junction, the drone waits with the patience of something that has been taught to see everything and prevent nothing.



The rain comes in from the lake before Emeka speaks again. Not the managed precipitation of the corporate zones " not AtmoSync's calculated seasonal palette, not *Alpine Morning* piped into clean air. This rain is the lake's own, redistributed by atmospheric processors that exist to protect the Spire, which means it falls here, on the Lateral Junction, on oxidized iron and standing water and Felicitas Madrigal pressing his forearm against his left ribs while the package stays warm against his chest. He registers the rain the way he registers distances " as information, as fact, as something to mark.

"The contact who flagged the shrine location," Emeka says through the relay. His voice has stopped shaking and that is worse. Stopped shaking means he has found the thing that explains the shaking, and found it whole. "The contact who flagged the shrine location is

Every Road Leads Back

someone I've used for three years. Someone I —" A pause. Not calculation. "The timing matches the chip deposit. Four hours before the chip appeared on the shrine, someone in my network pushed coordinates to an ACS sub-contractor routing account. I didn't see it because the push came from inside the mesh. From inside my mesh." Another pause, and in the pause Ash hears the particular silence of a man looking at something he built and finding a door in it he did not put there. "I'm sorry," Emeka says, which is not a thing Ash expected him to say, and the flatness of it makes it worse. "I'm running the asset now. I'll have a name in eight minutes."

Brisa appears at the edge of the cart's shadow. She has been gone four minutes and twelve seconds —" Ash knows because he counted in route increments, the way he always counts, *Waukegan lateral to the overpass, four minutes flat if you don't dog-leg* —" and she is dry in the places that suggest she had cover and wet everywhere else, and she looks at him against the wheel housing and then she looks at the package still under his coat and then she says, flat, the technical voice, the voice she uses for blast radii and structural assessments: "The integrity needs verification. After an ambush, protocol requires." She does not ask. She waits.

He opens the gray cloth. He does it the way he does everything —" *mark it*, deliberate, unhurried, the hands of a man who has learned that urgency is usually a lie someone tells you to make you move wrong. Inside the cloth there is a sealed document sleeve, water-resistant, old manufacture, the kind that costs more than it should. He opens the sleeve. There are two things inside. The first is what Brisa is looking for —" evidence, technical, dense, the kind that stops demolition orders when it reaches the right hands, and he registers this without reading it in full because his eyes have already found the second thing and his eyes have stopped. It is a custody filing. Paper, not digital —" someone paid for paper, paid for the permanence of it, paid for the thing that cannot be edited after the fact. The date is eleven years ago. He is named in it. *Absent party*. Not *unknown party*, not *whereabouts unknown* —" *absent*. Someone had found him, had his name, had looked for him and found only his absence and written that absence into the document as a legal fact. The child named in the filing was three years old at the time of filing. The child named in the filing is fourteen now. The block in Escanaba is twelve stories, poured concrete, three hundred and forty units. *Mark it*.

He is outside the cart before he understands he has moved. The rain on his face is cold and

Every Road Leads Back

specific and he is sitting in it — not leaning, *sitting*, on the wet gravel of the Lateral Junction with the filing in his hands, the paper going soft at the edges, and his other hand has found the stitched pocket and the red thread is coming apart between his fingers, the knot finally giving after years of his thumb finding it in the dark and not pulling. The photograph inside is small, worn at the corners from pressing against cloth for eleven years, from being carried toward a destination he had not admitted was a destination. A child, three years old, looking at whoever held the camera with an expression he knows from the inside — *cataloguing, filing, marking* — and he holds it in the rain and does not make a sound because the sound would cost more than he has, and above him the drone descends to ground level, four meters, three, two, and simply hovers there in the rain, present, watching, unable to do the one thing that would matter. Brisa sits down next to him. She does not ask. She does not speak. She sits down in the wet gravel of the Lateral Junction in the redistribution rain and is there, and Ash holds the photograph of a three-year-old who is now fourteen and lives in a building someone is trying to bring down, and the rain says what rain in the Glooms always says: *someone else decided this, and you have been living inside their decision your entire adult life, and you did not know, and you did not know.*



Act 3: The Road That Walks Back

The rain does not stop. He is aware of this as information — the rain does not stop, the gravel is wet, the photograph is getting wet, his ribs are a specific complaint on the left side every time he breathes. He tucks the photograph back into the stitched pocket, the thread already undone, the knot already gone, and he does not re-tie it. He leaves the pocket open. He sits another forty seconds in the rain, counting in route increments, and then he says, without preamble, without looking at either of them, to the drone and to the woman beside him and to whoever is above them somewhere with a relay and a name he has not asked for yet: "Her name is Hadi. She is fourteen." A pause. The long exhale, the one that precedes his disagreements. "She lives in the building. The twelve-story. Unit four-eleven, or she did —" that was three years ago, which is the last time I walked those streets. People move. I have not updated the information." He turns the custody filing over in his hands, not reading it,

Every Road Leads Back

just holding it, the paper gone soft at the edges. "I know the layout. The fire corridors. The loading dock on the northern face" it is not on any public schematic, it was poured into the original foundation and then sealed when the building changed hands. I know it because I memorized the building before I stopped being allowed inside it." He stops. He has said what needed saying. He does not add to it.

Above them, the drone holds position. No tilt. No reorientation. Emeka is not processing" Emeka is listening, and the stillness of the drone is the shape of that.

Brisa says nothing for eleven seconds. He knows because he counts them the same way. Then she says, flat, the technical voice: "Northern loading dock. Unsealed or sealed-accessible." Not a question. Inventory.

"Sealed-accessible," Ash says. "There is a junction box on the exterior wall, orange paint, the paint is faded to salmon now, I would not call it orange anymore. Behind the junction box the access panel opens inward. The latch mechanism corrodes in lake air" you press up before you pull, not pull directly. You understand where I am." He pauses. "The legal office that can act on this filing is three blocks from the loading dock. There is no checkpoint between them that runs Arcturus credentials. There is a Ferrogate Transit kiosk with a six-second authentication delay. I know the count." Another pause, the long one, the one that is not hesitation. "I have been avoiding this city for eleven years. I know every street in it." He says this the way he says all true things" without inflection, without emphasis, as if the weight of it is self-evident and he is simply naming the fact. *Los mapas mienten. Tu cuerpo sabe.* He does not say this aloud.

"Eight minutes," Emeka says through the relay, and his voice is level now, the shaking gone, but level the way a surface goes level after something has passed through it. "Eight minutes to the name. Then I'm pulling the entire drone net north. Every relay I have between here and Escanaba. It will take" a pause, calculation" "twelve minutes to reposition for coverage over the block." He stops. Then, quieter, the voice of someone who has just understood something about what they are for: "The northern face. I'll want the loading dock on thermal."



Every Road Leads Back

Eight minutes is longer than it sounds when you are sitting in the rain.

The name comes. Ash does not write it down. He files it the way he files everything “ in the body, in the count between steps, in the place where mnemonics live. He says it once, quiet, to himself, and it sits in his mouth with the specific weight of a thing that has always been true and has only now been given a sound. Emeka's voice says *pulling north* and the drone overhead rises without ceremony and is gone, and then it is just Ash and Brisa and the rain and the Lateral Junction and the filing going soft in his hands, and Brisa stands without being asked and offers nothing except the direction of her body, which is north, which is Escanaba, which is the only direction there is now.



The legal office opens at half-past six. He knows this because he memorized the schedule eleven years ago and has updated it twice through intermediaries, the way he updates all information he cannot afford to let go stale. The attorney on duty is a woman he has never met, but the documents she receives are the kind that speak for themselves “ evidence, technical, dense, the custody filing with the absent party named and present now, standing in her doorway at half-past six in the rain with a demolition order and a package that smells of someone's floor. She reads. She reads carefully, the way lawyers read when they know they are looking at something that will cost someone something large, and Ash stands without fidgeting, without reciting, without touching the frame of his synthetic eye. The suspension order goes out at seven-fourteen. He does not watch her send it. He is already outside.



The eastern face of the building catches the sunrise the way Old Harbor does “ unobstructed, no atmospheric processor close enough to redirect it, the light coming in flat and warm off the lake and hitting the poured concrete in a way that makes the whole twelve stories look briefly like something that was built with intention. Ash stands on the opposite side of the street and looks at this for a long time. He had forgotten. He had been carrying the building in his mind for eleven years as a problem, as a structure, as a blast radius and a

Every Road Leads Back

loading dock and a corroded latch mechanism “ and he had forgotten that in the morning it looks like this. The E.L.F. shrine is bolted to the doorframe at hip height, the small kind, ceramic cup at the base, the cup dry. He crosses the street. He does not hurry. He pours two fingers of filtered lake water into the cup “ the last of the bottle, the same bottle from the Waukegan shrine “ and then he takes the photograph from the open pocket, the stitched pocket with the thread already undone, and he holds it for a moment in the morning light, a three-year-old looking at whoever held the camera with his eyes, with his grandmother's eyes, with the eyes of everyone he has ever been. He slides it into the waterproof sleeve. He writes the relay address on the back in his careful hand, the geographic shorthand he uses, the address that reaches him through three intermediaries and two rest stops and one woman in Kenosha who has been holding messages for him for longer than she knows. He has never written it down before. He sets it against the shrine, face-up, weighted at the corner with the bottle cap from his coat pocket “ the same kind he has been leaving at shrines between here and the Crossing for forty years.



Brisa is across the street. She does not move toward him. She watches the way she watches structural assessments “ cataloguing, filing, not interfering with the load. Emeka's smallest drone hovers at his eye level, two meters away, matte gray, recording nothing. Just present. He turns from the doorframe. He turns south, toward the hyperlane, toward the Crossing, toward the road that has always been the only home he knew how to keep. He walks. His ribs make their specific complaint on the left side with each step and he does not touch the pocket, does not touch the frame of his synthetic eye, does not begin the recitation. The morning light off the lake is on his face, the amber glow of the synthetic eye and the warm brown of the other one both catching it, both warm, both looking at the same road. He does not know if she will find it. He does not know if finding it will be enough. He has forty years of evidence that the road does not care what you need it to mean. He walks slowly. He does not recite. *Los mapas mienten*. He does not say this. He is, for the first time in eleven years, not trying to mark the distance between himself and something. He is simply in it.

CHAPTER 3

Every Road Leads Back

